

payments, and her student loans were coming due. But she was able to meet her basic payments with her paycheck, and took care of the rest, such as gas and sometimes groceries, with credit. Her savings were long gone, and she had no extra money to put anything away anyway. She was active in her church, but felt it would be more responsible to pay her bills instead of giving to church. When the offering plate came by, she became quite good at stuffing a small bill in her hand and tucking it into a plate so no one would notice she never gave with a check or used an envelope.

For a while she tried to pay down her credit cards by paying five dollars over the minimum, but the balance never seemed to change. Her credit, however, was good, since she was making at least minimum payments. Once or twice when her checking account was nearly empty several days before payday, she took a cash advance from a credit card and deposited it in her checking account. And often when she went out with friends she would offer to “make things easier” by charging the meal on her card and collecting cash from her friends, thereby tiding her over to the next payday.

But then her old washer gave out for good. It was not worth repairing again. This happened the week she had finally acknowledged that her car’s bald tires needed to be replaced, which she paid for with the money that should have gone to her cell phone bill. She had been used to juggling monthly bills for years, but never was able to catch up. Paying a double cell phone bill one month meant she had to skip the cable bill, so that had to be doubled the next month. She was habitually a month late on her car payment. She even began to fall behind on her credit card payments, leaving her with no credit to use to buy a new washer. Beth didn’t know anyone else in her circle of friends who was forced to go to a Laundromat. She was embarrassed to be in her midthirties and outwardly successful in her career, but with only a drawer full of bills to show for it. She was in so much debt she told herself she’d still be working to pay it all off when she was eighty. She was generally happy with her life, had a close circle of friends, a wide